

THE ROLE OF CONFLICT MANAGEMENT STYLES AND CONTENT-SPECIFIC TRAINING ACROSS ORGANIZATIONAL BOUNDARIES

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INTRODUCTION

Our interest in this study is to examine the situation of inter-organizational contact where no normative mechanisms for cooperation or coordination exist and conflict is likely to occur. Under these circumstances, the interaction between the boundary spanners becomes the only level at which inter-organizational relationships can be initiated. Our objective therefore, is to elucidate the nature of the individual level interactions across organizational boundaries. Past research has shown that when there is no organization-level situation or a strong context which elicits an appropriate behavior from the individual, individuals rely primarily on their own personal characteristics (Tenbreunsel & Messick, 1999). Our interest is in the management of conflict between the two organizations and facilitation of cooperative exchanges, thus we examine the boundary spanning individual's conflict management style as a personal characteristic. We further believe that the extent to which the organizations recognize and support boundary-spanning activities in general may affect the employees' interactions and thus, examine the moderating effects of the content-specific training (e.g., intercultural cooperation, managing conflicts, coping with stress, etc.).

CONCEPTUAL FRAMEWORK AND HYPOTHESES

Contact and Problems

When boundary spanning employees from one organization contact employees from another organization, they experience high exposure to others (Manev & Stevenson, 2001) and hence, have numerous opportunities for social comparison (Bartel, 2001). Moreover, in the situations of social comparison individuals rely on their primary identification with their own organization (Hogg et al., 1990) and confirm their affiliation by showing ingroup favoritism and outgroup hostility (Tajfel & Turner, 1986). These negative categorization processes incite antagonism from employees of one organization toward members of another organization, who may, in turn, respond with animosity and annoyance toward the first individuals (Labianca et al., 1998). This

may disrupt interaction between the boundary spanners from different organizations and create problems in their communication. This leads us to hypothesize,

Hypothesis 1 (H1): The greater the frequency and importance of contact between two boundary-spanning individuals from different organizations the greater the frequency, seriousness, and importance of problems they will experience.

The Moderating Role of Conflict Management Styles

There has long been debate about whether conflict management styles in particular can be considered as stable traits (Carnevale, 1986). De Dreu et al (2001) argue that the dual concern model (Pruitt & Rubin, 1986) allows for conflict management behavior to arise from both personality and situational factors as both can influence concern for self and concern for other. Friedman et al., (2000) also show that individuals possess conflict management styles or configurations and patterns of styles that are relatively stable over time. Based on the above we conclude that individuals can possess a preferred conflict management style which he or she can draw upon to manage interpersonal conflict.

Conflict management research based on the dual concern model (Pruitt & Rubin, 1986) further argues that there are five conflict management styles, forcing or dominating, compromising, integrating or problem solving, avoiding, and accommodating which are functions of concern for self and concern for others. Although it is difficult to characterize one particular conflict management style as “effective” or “not effective” (Munduate et al., 1999), one of the behaviors that has been most effective across a wide variety of studies and situations is integrating or problem-solving (De Dreu, Weingart & Kwon, 2000). Likewise, two of the styles most commonly associated with ineffectiveness are dominance and avoidance (Morris et al., 1998).

Employees that exhibit domineering or avoiding conflict management styles have low concern for others (De Dreu et al, 2001). Low concern for others, in turn, is usually associated with distrust and lack of respect (Pruitt & Rubin, 1986) that may create an environment of arrogance and conceit (Tinsley et al, 2002). For example, Tinsley et al (2002) indicate how initial distrust can create a Pygmalion effect and force both parties in conflict to react distributively. In this context, employees who have to sustain high levels of contact with employees from another organization may experience more severe problems. Therefore we propose,

Hypothesis 2a (H2a): The individual’ conflict management style will moderate the relationship between the intensity of his or her contact with another employee and perception of problems. That is, employees with high level of contact will experience more problems when they have domineering or avoiding conflict management styles.

Employees that exhibit accommodating, integrating, or compromising conflict management styles typically have high concern for others (De Dreu et al, 2001) and greater social orientation. High concern for others is usually associated with greater trust and confidence (Lewicki & Stevenson, 1997; Murnighan et al., 2001) that create the environment of cooperation, sociability, empathy, and good interpersonal relationships (Triandis, 1995). A sense of cooperation and teamwork cultivated by the employees who exhibit high concern for others may reduce overall intergroup bias (Gaertner et al., 1990; Tsui et al., 1992) that employees from different organizations develop as they contact each other. This usually leads to less depletion of energy, lower levels of conflict and less competition—qualities that past research has attributed to more

satisfactory communication processes (Bishop & Scott, 2000; Jehn et al., 1999; West & Wallace, 1991). Therefore, we predict,

Hypothesis 2b (H2b): The individual's conflict management style will moderate the relationship between the intensity of his or her contact with another employee and perception of problems between the two. That is, employees with high level of contact will experience fewer problems when they have accommodating, integrating, and compromising conflict management styles.

The Moderating Role of Training

We define training as a set of educational activities offered by either an organization to its employees or the third party to provide knowledge about organizational goals, mission and rules and promote personal awareness about individual differences in the workplace, improve individuals' skills in conflict and stress management and intercultural communication. Research suggests that in general training is effective (Lipsey & Wilson, 1993) because it generally heightens egalitarian attitudes by promoting better understanding of self and others, increasing sensitivity to others, and fostering tolerance to the others' behavior (Campbell et al., 1970). For instance, research on cross-cultural training (CCT) explains how CCT helps people adjust to (Pruegger & Rogers, 1994) and interact effectively with individuals from another culture (Black & Mendenhall, 1990; Fiedler et al., 1971; Harrison, 1992). Therefore, we propose,

Hypothesis 3a (H3a): Training in intercultural communication will moderate the relationship between employees' contact and problems between them. That is, employees with high level of contact will experience fewer problems when they are specifically trained in intercultural communication.

Training can also help people override personal biases, develop tolerance, and learn to act in ways that can improve their work environment (Friedman et al., 2000). For instance, training in negotiations may help employees to find a mutually acceptable solution to the problem confronting different parties and thus, effectively manage their interactions. Similarly, through the training in mediation employees may learn a variety of strategies and tactics to initiate and facilitate successful interactions between employees of different organizations. Training in conflict management may also assist employees to become aware of the opposing individual's reactions to the perception that one's own and other party's current aspirations cannot be achieved simultaneously (DeChurch & Marks, 2001). We argue that this tolerance will lead to better understanding between two parties and will promote cooperation and sensitivity towards the other. This leads us to hypothesize,

Hypothesis 3b (H3b): Training in mediation, negotiation and managing conflicts will moderate the relationship between employees' contact and problems between them. That is, employees with high level of contact will experience fewer problems when they are trained in negotiation, mediation, and managing conflicts.

We argue that training with respect to organizational goals, rules and missions enhances the understanding of the other parties' positions and thus, may provide a sufficient level of confidence. A sense of confidence helps employees persevere in the face of adversity (Gully et al., in press) and may stimulate effective collaboration between the parties. Likewise, knowing about specific goals and rules suggests that employees share basic assumptions about the correct way to perceive, think, and feel in relation to the problem (Schein, 1991). We argue that such

congruency in perceptions may influence the relationship between contact and problems. Therefore, we predict,

Hypothesis 3c (H3c): Familiarity with organizational goals, mission and rules will moderate the relationship between employees' contact and problems between them. That is, employees with high level of contact will experience fewer problems when they are familiar with organizational goals, mission and rules.

In summarizing the early literature on boundary spanning, Miles and Perrault (1976: 21) state that "boundary relevance, inferred from the frequency of contacts with individuals outside a focal person's own organization, has been shown to be directly associated with the degree of experience role conflict." Past research has shown that role conflict is normally associated with stress (Van Sell, Brief, & Schuler, 1981; Friedman & Polodny, 1992). Moreover, implicit in Adams' (1976) 'distrust cycle' experienced by boundary spanners is the idea that boundary spanners must resolve ethical and trust-based dilemmas in their boundary spanning role. The inability to do so also results in role conflict and stress. Therefore, we predict:

Hypothesis 3d (H3d): Training in how to cope with stress and manage ethical dilemmas will moderate the relationship between employees' contact and problems between them. That is, employees with high level of contact will experience fewer problems when they are trained in how to cope with stress and manage ethical dilemmas.

METHOD

Inter-Organizational Setting

Our subjects are the UN peacekeeping military forces: Dutch contingent of NATO Implementation Force (IFOR) and Stabilization Force (SFOR) troops who have been mandated to create peace between warring parties. The other player in our study are personnel in non-governmental organizations (NGOs) who provide critical material and human resources, and intervene to provide social services to those in need and to prevent civilian casualties. The interaction between these two major third-party organizations is necessary for effective peace building; however, several reports on peacekeeping operations have alluded to problems between peacekeepers and NGO personnel due to differences in goals, missions and mandates (Aall, 2000; Report of the Panel on United Nations Peace Operations, 2000). For many NGOs in humanitarian situations, the fact remains that their ability to gain donations and grants is directly related to their ability to be where there is most need, and that does not always match peacekeeping priorities. Last (2000) further points out that peacekeeping missions are organized for stopping violence and the NGOs are organized for building relationships but both capabilities are needed together to build peace.

Sample

Our sample includes 850 Dutch military peacekeepers on missions. The survey was sent to all officers who have been on peacekeeping missions between 1995-1999, and low ranked officers of military police as they were trained and have relatively intense contact with parties on the ground (over 52% response rate). The age of officers ranged from 23 to 58 years with a mean of 41 years. The majority of officers were male (97.3%). Military rank ranged from sergeant to general with the majority of captain (25%) and major (20%). Years of military service ranged from two years to 39 years with a mean of 20 years. Fifty five percent of officers

served in land-forces, 3% served in Navy, 4% were in Air-forces, and the remaining served in military police.

Measures

Contact with NGOs. This variable is a composite of frequency and importance of contact between UN peacekeepers and NGOs and was measured using two items from the survey.

Problems with NGOs. Three survey items were available to measure this variable. Participants were asked to estimate *how frequently* they faced problems between their team/unit and GO/NGO on a Likert scale from 1 (hardly ever) to 5 (daily), *how serious* these problems were (from 1 = not at all to 5 = very serious), and to what degree they had been *personally involved* in these problems (from 1 = not at all to 5 = heavily involved).

Conflict management style. This was measured with the twenty items responding to the question “how did you *in general* manage personal frictions and differences of opinion or interest with others during your latest mission” on a Likert scale from 1 (never) to 5 (always). We ran a confirmatory factor analysis and obtained a five-factor solution which corresponded to integrating (Cronbach’s $\alpha = .75$), dominating ($\alpha = .74$), avoiding ($\alpha = .73$), accommodating ($\alpha = .65$) and compromising conflict management style ($\alpha = .76$).

Training. Participants were asked to evaluate training in specific subjects such as intercultural communication, mediation, negotiation and managing conflicts, familiarity with organizational goals, missions and rules, coping with stress and managing ethical dilemmas. Participants were also asked to evaluate separately the importance of the topic and whether this topic been addressed during the training on a Likert scale from 1 = not at all to 10 = absolutely yes. We operationalized our training variable as a composite of these two scores (i.e. importance of the topic and whether this topic been addressed).

Controls. We included year of military service as a control variable. Years of military service reflect competence and expertise that may affect participants’ perception of their problems with NGOs.

RESULTS

The correlation between contact and problems with NGOs was significant and positive. As expected, all components of the problems with NGOs were highly interrelated. We further examine the relationships between contact, problems, training, and conflict management styles using hierarchical regression analyses.

The moderating effects of conflict management styles.

In support of H1, we found that the relationships between contact between UN peacekeepers and NGOs and their problems (frequency, seriousness, and personal involvement) were significant and positive ($Beta = .309, p < .001$, $Beta = .343, p < .001$, and $Beta = .480, p < .001$, respectively).

In partial support of H2a, we found that UN peacekeepers that had frequent interactions with NGOs were likely to report more problems with NGOs when they exhibited an avoiding conflict management style. Hypothesis 2b, predicting the moderating effects for accommodating, integrating, and compromising conflict management styles, was not supported.

The moderating effects of content-specific training.

H3a, predicting the moderating effects of training in intercultural communication, was not supported. In partial support of H3b, we found that UN peacekeepers that were in high contact with NGOs were likely to report less frequent and serious problems with NGOs and be less personally involved when they were trained in managing conflict with other parties. H3c, predicting the moderating effects of training in familiarity/specificity with high-order organizational goals, mission and rules was not supported. In partial support of H3d, we found that UN peacekeepers that had frequent interactions with NGOs were likely to report less frequent problems and less personal involvement with NGOs when they were trained in how to cope with stress and manage ethical dilemmas.

DISCUSSION

We extend the theoretical literature by looking at the personal characteristics of boundary spanners contributing to effective conflict management and content-specific training in a context of inter-organizational contact where there are few mechanisms that facilitate cooperation. Our results show that employees who frequently encounter employees from another organization in such situations are likely to report more problems when they exhibit an avoiding conflict management style. This fits past research which holds that avoidance is not traditionally considered as an effective conflict management style and in fact, it promotes conflict (Friedman et al., 2000) and creates problems. We also found that training had significant effects on peacekeepers' perceptions of their ability to manage the problems with NGO personnel. Specifically, our results show that employees who frequently encounter employees from other organizations were likely to report less severe problems when they are trained in managing conflict, ethical dilemmas and how to cope with stress. Our findings are consistent with the previous research confirming that such training can be potentially helpful (Last, 2000; Leeds, 2001).

We realize that correlation between contact with NGOs and problems with NGOs does not indicate a causal relationship which is common in field studies. Another limitation of this data is that it does not describe the entire range of actors affecting the interaction of peacekeepers and NGOs. Specifically, data from NGO personnel and from local parties is not available, which is critical for determining the ultimate success of peacekeeping and NGO cooperation on local peace. In the future we plan to validate our finding through methods such as surveys and structured interviews of NGO personnel and local parties. We further intend to use data from other peacekeeping missions, for example, UNAMSIL in Sierra Leone, to compare the relationship across conflict areas. Another future avenue for research is to examine the impact of the organizational context of UN peacekeepers and NGOs (e.g., militaristic versus non-militaristic mission context) on perceptions of their problems.

To our knowledge, this study is one of the first empirical studies to investigate the inter-organizational contact between NGOs and UN peacekeepers and examine the moderating effect of content-specific training. We believe that this study might help to influence the way in which contemporary organizations leverage their external interactions (e.g. strategic alliances and cooperative networks), produce greater combined effectiveness, efficiencies in resources, and better results in implementing joint operations in the future.

REFERENCES AVAILABLE FROM AUTHOR

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